MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM
MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR EXAMINATION MARCH 2025
SECOND SEMESTER
Multi-Disciplinary Courses (MDC) - MG2MDCHIS100
FILMIC APPROACHES TO HISTORY
(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 1.5 Hours **Maximum Marks: 50**

Part A
Short Answers
Answer any 5 questions Each question carries 2 marks.

1. **Name a famous historical film that uses reenactment as a central storytelling technique.** [K] / [CO4, CO5]
   Kerala Varma Pazhassi Raja (value liberally)
2. **Name any two problem centric films**. [A] / [CO4] - *Elipathayam, Oridathu*
3. **What is the focus of MSS Pandian's Image Trap?** [An] / [CO5]
   About MGR's characters in films which were mostly heroic, just, and self-sacrificing images.
4. **What is the main difference between historiography and historiophoty?** [U] / [CO2]
   Historiography is the process of representation of history through words whereas historiophoty is the process of representation of history through images.
5. **Which historical figure is depicted in Kerala Varma Pazhassi Raja?** [An] / [CO5]
   He was the ruler of Kottayam kingdom in Malabar region, and fought against the British East India Company
6. **What is the role of Natali Zemon Davis in film Historiography?** [E] / [CO2]
   Films can be considered as source of history - two types of historical films-films about historical personalities and films whose plot is set in historical contexts
7. **What is the significance of imagination in Historical films?** [E] / [CO3]
   Imagination can fill in the gaps in historical records, can bring past to life, can present socio-cultural practices of a place
8. **Why is film review important in analyzing historicity?** [An] / [CO5]
   Film reviews can give more insights into the cultural and political context of a film and can verify the facts presented in the film

Part B
Short Essay
Answer any 4 questions Each question carries 5 marks

9. **What are the limits of imagination in films?** [E] / [CO3]
   Filmmakers are expected to remain faithful to documented/historical facts, which may restrict their freedom of using imagination creatively when representing historical events or personalities- Cannot distort facts when audiences are familiar with the plot- They have ethical and legal responsibilities when presenting historical figures- If the plot is linked to national pride, any sort of imagination that distorts facts may provoke political and social reactions

10. **How has the study of film history evolved during time?** [U] / [CO1]
    Annales found in 1929 by Marc Bloch and Lucien Fabvre- led to the rise of new sources of history- Post Modernism considers past as containing several possibilities. The past is constructed by historian using facts and his/her own imagination- Thus, films started to be considered as a valid source of history. Three approaches to study film and history- can study history of film industry, Films as historical documents, -provide info about the societies which made and watched them, Film as a medium for presenting versions of the past.

11. **Why is representation of film important for marginalized communities?** [A] / [CO4]
    Helps to reaffirm their existence- can present their culture and experiences- can help to build their identity and pride- can help to dismantle the stereotypes that have been perpetuated over time- can promote social inclusion- helps to preserve their culture- can provide a space to present their struggles for justice
12. **How do films shape national identity?** [A] / [CO4]
    Films can represent narrate histories of the nation- can dramatize main historical events, create shared memories, shape collective understanding of the nation's past- can promote national customs, language, folklore, music- can create national heroes and myths- can reflect national values like freedom, democracy, unity- can even critique narratives of the government- unify diverse population

13. **What are the major themes explored in Thuramuhkam?** [An] / [CO5]
    Thuramukham is a 2023 Malayalam film directed by Rajeev Ravi and written by Gopan Chidambaram- portrays the brutal *chappa* system at the Kochi port, ie., where metal tokens were thrown at workers- highlighted systemic exploitation and lack of dignity in labor- presented rise of trade unionism and collective resistance against the unjust labor practices- examines how political consciousness emerges among the working class, leading to organized protests.

14. **Discuss the relationship between cinema and modernity in the early 20th century.** [U] / [CO1]

    Films started to be considered as valid historical sources through the works of post modern historians like Robert Rosenstone, Hayden White, Natalie Davis etc- films reflect everyday life- uses modern technology- enhances global connectivity- critiques socio-cultural and political conditions- helps to form perceptions- source for mass entertainment

15. **What are the main Features of Historical Films?** [E] / [CO3]

    Three approaches to study film and history- can study history of film industry, Films as historical documents, -provide info about the societies which made and watched them, Film as a medium for presenting versions of the past. Historical films- should tell history as a story- focus on individuals, events or process-shows closed past-can emotionalize history-help audience to see the past-can summarize or condense events-can invent characters or events.

Part C
Essay Questions
Answer any 2 questions Each question carries 10 marks

16. **Discuss how ideology influences the interpretation of history in popular historical films.** [U] / [CO1]

    Filmmakers may align the narrative with popular political or cultural ideologies- may ignore certain events or personalities, while favoring some others- can promote nationalism and patriotism-may simplify complex events or processes like the British colonialism- may silence marginalized groups- may try to bring historical contexts into the modern moral frameworks-can influence public perceptions

17. **Explain the influence of films on Society.** [U] / [CO1]

    Films can influence people's perceptions on politics, society and culture- can spread values, traditions, and lifestyles-can raise awareness on topics like inequality, climate change, discriminations etc-can challenge stereotypes – reinforce societal norms-influence fashion, language, habits, career aspirations-can evoke empathy-can inspire movements and protests-foster global connectivity

18. **Examine how Chemmeen and 1956, Central Travancore represent the lives of marginalized communities.** [An] / [CO5]

    Chemmeen is a 1965 Malayalam film directed by Ramu Karyatt- Focuses on fishing community in Kerala, highlights caste-based restrictions and discrimination, depicts the conflict between love and tradition, shows how religion and superstition control daily life, explores strict gender roles and female suppression, portrays economic struggle and lack of opportunities, ends tragically, showing the cost of challenging social norms.

    1956, Central Travancore is 2019 Malayalam film directed by Don Palathara- focuses on landless settlers during Kerala's land reform era, shows migration into forests in search of livelihood, focuses on lower-class characters and their silent struggles, depicts survival in harsh, environments, realistic portrayal of marginalization of certain communities, emphasizes the legacy of feudal and colonial inequality, highlights economic displacement and lack of land rights,

19. **In What ways can different modes of Emplotment (romance, tragedy, comedy, satire) influence the interpretation in Film History.** [E] / [CO2]

    Hayden White defines emplotment as the process of turning historical events into a structured narrative. Historians do not just record facts; they shape them into meaningful stories using literary structures. The same historical events can be told in different ways depending on the emplotment chosen- The film *Iyyobinte Pusthakam* intertwines protagonist's romantic relationship with his fight for justice, in the backdrop of British colonization. The film *Chemmeen* reflects the tragic consequences of caste, tradition, and superstition within a marginalized community, offering insight into historical social structures. The film *Sandesham* uses satire and comedy to expose the absurdities of political ideologies and party rivalries.